

The Memory FADEOUT

The what, how and why of dementia, a dreaded disease that is looming large over the nation. How serious is the threat?

| By Damayanti Datta |

If you ever saw a house filled with lights and someone turning those off one by one, then you know what happened to her brain. The first signs were small and all too easy to dismiss. She started losing words and could barely sustain a conversation. Slowly, as the spreading darkness of Alzheimer's took over, she forgot how to cook, tell the time on a clock, dial a phone and speak five out of six languages she knew. She also lost all the favourite tunes that she hummed aloud all her life. For the gutsy mother,

who worked tirelessly to bring up two children after the sudden death of her husband, snapping pea pods takes concentration—lots of it—now. There's no cure and no way to stop the lights from "turning off" in her brain. At least, not yet.

"Not yet" is the operative word, full of wonderful deniability. For few recognise that a dementia upsurge is looming over India. And the nation doesn't even have the disease on its radar. At the first National Dementia Strategy meet held in Delhi this month, it was declared that India would be among the top five dementia hubs by 2020. If there are 24.3

million dementia patients in the world, India is believed to have nearly 3.5 million, rising at a rate that is three to four times higher than the developed world. Each of our five metros have 30,000 to 50,000 such patients. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), from one in 20 above 65 years of age suffering from dementia, India will face a steep rise of one-in-four sufferers in the near future.

What explains the rising numbers? "Age," says Dr Sheilu Sreenivasan of Mumbai, "It is the only known risk factor for dementia. As a person grows older, the Alzheimer's risk

goes up too. After 60, it's one in 20, but after 80 it is one in five." With rise in longevity, growth rate among the 80-plus segment has jumped up, explains Sreenivasan, the president of Dignity Foundation, a charitable organisation with social support deliveries for senior citizens. "The number of dementia patients is also growing at a phenomenal rate," she adds. To Nirmala Narula, vice-chairperson, Alzheimer's and Related Disorders Society of India (ARDSI), there's more awareness now. "So many more people come to us. Our helplines are constantly engaged these days," she says.

The toxic brew for dementia is lifestyle, says Dr P.N. Renjen, senior neurosurgeon with Apollo Indraprastha, Delhi: "In India, dementia in the wake of strokes or cerebro-vascular diseases is very common—nearly 30 to 40 per cent." Hardly a surprise as the country gallops into the present, modernising and urbanising at blinding speed, western food habits take hold, physical activity drops alarmingly, long hours of work and stress make obesity, diabetes and other lifestyle disorders the order of the day. "There has been a surge in dementia triggered by strokes," says